

Remedies for Common Ailments

Herbal knowledge is continuing to grow as more people choose herbs as an alternative to pharmaceutical drugs. The following remedies are safe and effective treatments for a range of common ailments; but, like all medicines, they must be treated with respect. The suggestions given here are mostly quite straightforward. However, if you are unsure about what to do, always seek professional advice (see p. 320). For instructions on how to make herbal preparations, see pp. 290–297.

Essential Information

Before using remedies read the following.

Dosage

- Except in *Infants & Children* (see p. 318), all dosages given are for adults.
- Do not exceed the stated dose; doubling it will not make the medicine twice as effective.
- Before taking a remedy, check the cautions in the relevant herb entry (see pp. 56–283).
- Do not take more than 2 internal remedies at any one time or more than 1 internal and 1 external remedy for the same complaint, unless specified. Where different forms of a remedy are given (e.g. take tincture or infusion), the first is preferable.

How Long to Take Remedies

Take remedies until symptoms disappear. If there is no improvement within 2–3 weeks, if the condition worsens, or if in doubt, consult a professional practitioner (see p. 320).

Professional Advice

- Advice is given on when to seek professional guidance. Consult a professional if taking a remedy for over 3 weeks.

Infants & Children

- Do not give babies under 6 months any internal herbal (or other) medicine without professional advice.
- *Infants & Children*, p. 318, gives children's dosages.

Remedies elsewhere can be used for children under 12. Reduce doses as follows:

- 6–12 months old— $\frac{1}{10}$ adult dose
- 1–6 years old— $\frac{1}{3}$ adult dose
- 7–12 years old— $\frac{1}{2}$ adult dose.

Older People

Older adults, due to slower metabolism, may require less than the standard dose. Those over 70 should usually take $\frac{3}{4}$ of the adult dose.

Pregnancy

- During the first 3 months of pregnancy, avoid all medicines, herbal or otherwise, unless absolutely essential.
- Avoid alcoholic tinctures in pregnancy.
- The herbs mentioned in *Pregnancy* (see p. 317) are safe to use. Many of the remedies elsewhere in this section are also safe, but some are not. Always check the cautions for the remedy and in the relevant herb entry (see pp. 56–283) before taking an herb during pregnancy.

Prescription Medicine

As explained opposite, some herbs are known to interact with pharmaceutical drugs; others may interact in as-yet unknown ways. If you are taking a prescribed medicine, consult a professional practitioner before taking an herb, and do not discontinue any medicine without their approval.

Herbal Preparations

- All quantities are for dried herbs unless specified.
- Where more than one part of an herb is used, the instructions specify which part to use. Only use that part. Do not use seeds sold for horticultural purposes.
- Unless specified otherwise, preparations are made with standard quantities of dried herb, as follows:

Infusions (to make, see p. 291). Use a teaspoon of herb to a cup of water, or make enough for 3–4 doses using 20 g of herb to 2 cups (500 ml) of water. Use a covered container to retain the herb's valuable volatile oils.

Decoctions (to make, see p. 291). Use 20 g herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water.

Inhalations (to make, see p. 297). Add 5–10 drops essential oil to 1 quart (1 liter) of steaming hot water or use an infusion.

Lotions (to make, see p. 296). Use 2 cups (500 ml) infusion or decoction, or 5 tsp (25 ml) tincture diluted in 2 cups (500 ml) of water.

Tablets or capsules (to make, see p. 292). Many herbs are available over the counter in both forms. Take according to the instructions on the packet.

Tinctures (to make, see p. 292). Some tinctures are available ready-made. Take tinctures with cold water unless specified. Sometimes the number of drops recommended is given as a range, e.g. 20–40 drops. In these cases, start with the lowest amount and increase by 5–10 drops per dose as required.

Essential Oils

Do not take essential oils internally unless advised to do so by a professional practitioner. For external use, dilute essential oils with a carrier oil, such as sunflower or almond, in a ratio of 1 part essential oil to 20 parts carrier oil; e.g., 5 drops essential oil to 1 tsp (5 ml) carrier oil. For a bath, add 5–10 drops of neat essential oil to the running water. To use essential oils in massage, see p. 297.

Other Information

For other preparations, weighing & measuring, and equipment, see pp. 291–297.

Self-help

Lifestyle, diet and exercise advice is given in this section. In general, these suggestions do not provide a “quick-fix” solution and need to be followed long term if they are to be effective. They should be used in addition to the recommended herbal remedy. By ensuring that your body has the right nutrition and level of fitness, you protect yourself against many ailments such as infections and circulatory problems, as well as increase your chances of a speedy and effective recovery.



Infusions make effective remedies; some are also relaxing or refreshing drinks.